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Louise Glück's *Averno*: A Feminist Reception of the Myth of Persephone

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ABSTRACT
This paper examines the reception of the classical myth of Persephone in Louise Glück's 2006 poetry collection *Averno*. It argues that Glück reimagines Persephone's descent into the Underworld as a metaphorical framework for exposing the infernos young women experience in their transition to adulthood. In addition to situating *Averno* within the continuum of Persephone readings – spanning ancient and contemporary contexts – the paper identifies the reception strategies Glück employs to craft her critique. Drawing on the methods of Classical Reception Studies and Gender Studies, this analysis contributes to existing scholarship on *Averno* by showing how the author appropriates the myth through a female and feminist lens, hence providing a distinctly feminist appropriation of the story.

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Introduction

Louise Glück's 2006 poetry collection *Averno*[1] has sparked the attention of both readers and scholars for its piercing insights into the timeless and enigmatic topics of death and dying. Gosmann says *Averno* is "a memento mori collection of poems"[2] that urges readers to remain aware of the fact that death is to happen in the future. As noted in the opening epigraph, the book takes its title from a crater lake outside Naples, which Virgil described as the portal to Hades. The epigraph and title of the collection set a specific tone for the poems that follow and suggest a unifying theme, situating the stories told and the feelings evoked in the realm of the dead. Glück is an author fascinated with vertical journeys, in which, as she has said, "a spirit, a soul, is permitted access to the other realm and returns to speak of it".[3]

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[1]Louise Glück is a highly revered author in contemporary American poetry, having earned virtually every major literary award, including the Nobel Prize in Literature in 2020. She has published fourteen volumes of poetry, from her debut *Firstborn* (1968) to her most recent *Winter Recipes from the Collective* (2021). Critics and scholars have disagreed on how to interpret her oeuvre, especially due to the eclectic and erudite nature of her poems, which range from "the persona poem to blunt confessionalism to dialog to a kind of mock epic that, like Joyce's *Ulysses*, regards the author's life, however ironized, through a Homeric template" (Morris, *Thematic Introduction*, 1). Most critics agree that Glück's forte is the lyric poem, which she uses to express emotional conflict with her family. For a book-by-book overview of Glück's oeuvre, see ibid., esp. pages 3–13.

[2]Gosmann, "Psychoanalyzing Persephone," 219.

[3]Douglas, "Descending Figure," 117. Glück describes her poems as "vertical", explaining that they "aspire and they delve. They don't expand. They don't elaborate, or amplify" (ibid., 117). This sense of vertical descent, echoed in the title of her

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Whereas death lies beyond the confines of anyone's personal experience, Persephone is an expert in dying and being reborn. No wonder Glück chooses her for her testimony about experiences from and about Averno. Daughter of the harvest goddess Demeter, Persephone is the goddess of spring's bounty. In her youth, she is titled Kore, "the corn maiden", but once she is abducted by Hades, Persephone's uncle and the Lord of the Underworld, she becomes the goddess of the dead, and is mostly referred to as Persephone. The myth of Persephone is the intertext of *Averno*, evoked throughout the book both subtly and through explicit references to the story's characters, key episodes and mythological settings. Scholars often attempt to trace the classical sources Glück may have drawn upon,[4] but the poet herself never identifies a specific ancient text as her inspiration. Instead, she acknowledges a personal and affective relationship with myth,[5] grounded in her early encounters with *D'Aulaires' Book of Greek Myths*, which she read repeatedly as a child and remembers vividly.[6] This formative engagement laid the groundwork for the ways in which she later reimagined myth in her poetry.

In *Proofs and Theories: Essays on Poetry*, Glück describes myth as a tool for examining psychological states. In *Averno*, she appropriates the story of Persephone to explore its social and psychological dimensions, reimagining Persephone's literal journeys between the earth and the Underworld as metaphors for "family drama", particularly the love triangle between Persephone, Demeter and Hades. Psychoanalysis, another major influence on Glück's life and writings, also informs her reception of the myth in *Averno*. While most scholars have focused on this aspect of Glück's retelling,[7] it is equally important to remember (and examine accordingly) how the mythical episodes are mostly refigured from the daughter's point of view – or, more precisely, from a perspective that has Persephone's best interest in mind, defending her choices and making amends for her lack of interiority in the classical sources. This aligns with a broader movement of female authors revisiting Antiquity to provide a voice to ancient women and offer a fresh "reread" of female characters and life stories.[8]

1980 collection, *Descending Figure,* is also evident in her poetic subjects, such as Persephone, who frequently journey to the Underworld.

[4]Scholars frequently point to the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* and Ovid's *Metamorphoses* as the two classical sources to which Glück appears most indebted. *Averno* mirrors the narrative structure of the *Hymn* – abduction, maternal grief, divine negotiation, partial return, and the resulting seasonal cycle – while departing from its emphasis on Demeter's suffering. As Isobel Hurst notes, Glück's version "eschews the pathos of the mother's grief, and is closer to the Ovidian version in which Ceres is a vengeful destroyer, the instigator of widespread devastation" (Hurst, "Autumnal Underworld," 77). For further discussion of Glück's sources of inspiration, see Kichouh Aiadi, "Louise Glück's 'Persephone the Wanderer'" and "Psychoanalytic Approach."

[5]Discussing the composition of poems from *Averno*, Glück mentions the fear she felt during the September 11 attacks, when she was trapped in California and could not get home. This feeling of being trapped mirrors Persephone's situation in the Underworld after being taken by Hades (Hurst, "Autumnal Underworld," 77). Mary-Kate Azcuy adds that in *Averno*, both Demeter and Persephone relive a traumatic event each autumn, showing signs of post-traumatic stress similar to those experienced by 9/11 survivors (Azcuy, "Persona, Trauma and Survival").

[6]Gosmann, "Psychoanalyzing Persephone," 220. *D'Aulaires' Book of Greek Myths*, a classic children's book, retells various myths from Greek mythology, drawing on several ancient sources, especially the *Homeric Hymns* and Ovid's *Metamorphoses*. Glück's own mythic retelling is evocative of these two texts.

[7]See Morris, *Thematic Introduction*, 26–28; Gosmann, "Psychoanalyzing Persephone" and *Poetic Memory: The Forgotten Self*; Baker, "Versions of Ascesis in Louise Glück's Poetry"; Kichouh Aiadi, "Louise Glück's 'Persephone the Wanderer'," "Vulnerability, Resistance, Dependency" and "Psychoanalytic Approach"; Sastri, "Unbearable Birth."

[8]In contemporary literature, there is a wider trend in reappropriating ancient women and female mythological figures that extends beyond Persephone. Popular examples include *The Penelopiad* (Margaret Atwood 2005), *Pandora's Jar: Women in the Greek Myths* (Natalie Haynes 2020), *Medusa's Daughters* (Theodora Goss 2020) and *Medusa* (Jessie Burton and Olivia Lomenech Gill 2022).

Beyond psychoanalytic readings, several critics have examined Glück's reworking of classical myth from feminist perspectives.[9] El Bakary highlights her use of the Persephone myth as a self-mythologising device through which personal trauma is transformed into timeless allegory. Hamada Abdelwahed Muhammed explores Glück's creation of a female persona defined by ambiguity and endurance, while Rose considers her portrayal of women's vulnerability and lack of agency within romantic relationships. My analysis builds on these interpretations but diverges from them by focusing on the strategies of reception through which the author develops Persephone's voice and advances her revisionist mythmaking. In doing so, I situate *Averno* explicitly within the field of Classical Reception Studies.

Drawing on the theoretical frameworks of Classical Reception and Gender Studies, this paper examines the reception of the myth of Persephone in *Averno*, concentrating on Glück's use of the Underworld motif as it relates to Persephone's abduction by Hades and her descent into hell – the central episode of the original myth. My argument is that Glück uses these elements from myth to illuminate the metaphorical infernos young women encounter as they strive for independence in their passage to adulthood. Classical Reception scholar Lorna Hardwick's concept of "appropriation" provides a framework for this analysis. Hardwick describes appropriation as the use of "ancient images or texts to sanction subsequent ideas or practices".[10] To incorporate a Gender Studies perspective, I adopt the term "feminist appropriation", which refers to reinterpretations of classical myths by female authors that foreground women's perspectives and often critique patriarchal systems.[11]

This paper begins with an assessment of Persephone's representation in the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* and Ovid's *Fasti* and *Metamorphoses*, and more narrowly the representation of the mother-daughter and the wife-husband bonds in these sources. It then connects Glück's retelling with earlier trends in the reception of the Persephone myth, particularly the revisionist approaches to mythology prevalent in the latter half of the twentieth century. Drawing on both the ancient sources and modern receptions, this paper analyses a selection of poems from *Averno*, identifying the reception strategies Glück employs and examining the social and cultural factors that may inform and motivate her creative choices. Special attention is given to poems that advance Glück's feminist reading of the myth and thus support the paper's central thesis.

In Glück's reception, Persephone is overwhelmed by both her mother (Demeter) and lover (Hades). Each claims her love with an intensity that disregards her feelings and leaves her paralysed, condemned to a conflicted and divided existence. Unlike ancient accounts, in which Persephone longs to return to her mother, Glück's Persephone feels asphyxiated by familial and romantic ties alike, defined by her perpetual desire to escape both. By centring the narrative on the young protagonist, the poet provides a unique lens through which to examine the ties between husband and wife and mother

[9]El Bakary, "The Mythopoetics of Louise Glück"; Hamada Abdelwahed Muhammed, "The Female Persona"; Rose, "Women's Lack of Romantic Power."

[10]Hardwick, *Reception Studies*, 9. Building on Hardwick's notion of the "appropriation of the classics," the perspectives of Sanders (*Adaptation and Appropriation*) and Hutcheon (*Theory of Adaptation*) on "appropriation" and "adaptation" may also offer a productive framework.

[11]Friedman, *Psyche Reborn*; Ostriker, *Thieves of Language*. The concept of "feminist appropriation" is widely used by scholars working in Gender Studies. There are analogous terms available, such as "mythopoetic revisionism". For scholarship on other ways in which the term "feminist retelling" has been defined, see Doherty, *Gender and Myth*.

and daughter. Glück directs our attention to the concerns, transitions and instabilities that define young womanhood, showing solidarity with the daughter's experience and outlook, arguing that their path to adulthood is a journey to the Underworld, plagued with challenging tests and dangerous places. Ultimately, this paper demonstrates how Glück appropriates the Persephone myth to deliver a powerful critique of the systems of oppression that render daughters vulnerable in both mother-daughter and romantic relationships.

Demeter, Persephone and Hades in the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* and Ovid's *Metamorphoses* and *Fasti*

The varied and multifaceted presence of myth is almost a signature mark of Glück's poetic discourse. Exposed to Greek mythology from an early age, this influence is seen in important poetry collections such as *The Triumph of Achilles* (1985), *Meadowlands* (1996), *Vita Nova* (1999) and, of course, *Averno* (2006).[12] It is relevant to note that *Averno* does not mark Glück's first engagement with the myth of Demeter and Persephone. Her earlier poem "Pomegranate", included in her second collection of poetry *The House on Marshland* (1975), already signals her interest in the myth, framing it from the daughter's perspective. There, Persephone sides with Hades, suggesting that Demeter's protection has stifled her access to a more sensual and autonomous experience of the world.[13] This early treatment anticipates many of the themes Glück would return to and develop further in *Averno*. Before examining *Averno*, it is important to understand the tradition into which Glück is entering, because she responds directly to key ideas present across classical sources, offering a radical interpretation of the original Persephone story. This serves as a valuable first step towards the examination in this and the sections that follow of the creative (and inherently cultural) choices behind her retelling of Persephone.[14]

Literary versions of the myth were abundant in Antiquity, reflecting the widespread popularity of Demeter and Persephone in Greek culture and religion. While there are multiple classical texts that narrate the story of Persephone, sometimes with variations,[15] they consistently explore the powerful connection between mother and daughter, and the sorrow of their forced separation. The *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* (*c*. 650–550 BCE) and Ovid's accounts in Book IV of *Fasti* (*c*. 8 CE) and Book V of the *Metamorphoses* (*c*. 8 CE) stand out for their memorable portrayals of this relationship. The *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*, the earliest-known version of the myth, describes Persephone as a radiant and noble figure with a close bond with her mother (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 4–6, 370).

[12]Morris, *Thematic Introduction*, 25.
[13]For a close reading of this poem, see Hurst, "Love and Blackmail: Demeter and Persephone," 180.
[14]Hardwick, *Reception Studies*, 8.
[15]For scholarly work on the classical sources narrating the myth of Persephone, with extensive bibliography, commentary, and insights into the influence and reception of these texts, see Foley, *Hymn to Demeter*. The myth of Persephone is recounted in several key classical texts. These are the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*, Homer's *Odyssey* (*c*. 743–713 BCE) and *Iliad* (*c*. 750–725 BCE), Hesiod's *Theogony* (*c*. 700 BCE), Bacchylides' *Greek Lyric* (*c*. 520–450 BCE), Virgil's *Aeneid* (*c*. 20 BCE), Apollodorus' *The Library* (*c*. 1–2 CE), Ovid's *Metamorphoses* and *Fasti*, and Claudian's *The Rape of Proserpine* (*c*. 370–405 AD). Some works, like the *Hymn to Demeter* and Claudian's poem, are dedicated entirely to narrating Persephone's story, while other, such as those by Apollodorus and Ovid, weave the story into broader narratives, providing less elaborate accounts. Meanwhile, Homer, Hesiod, and Virgil do not narrate the myth directly but include brief mentions of the goddess, seeking her generosity or benevolence.

However, their idyllic existence on earth is shattered when Hades "snatched the unwilling maid into his golden chariot and led her off lamenting" (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 19–20). Demeter, devastated by her daughter's disappearance, tirelessly searches for her across the earth (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 40), neglecting her duties as the goddess of grain and agriculture, which results in a widespread famine. This crisis prompts Zeus to intervene and offer a compromise solution: he decrees that Persephone will split her time between the Underworld and the mortal world. This arrangement is based on the number of pomegranate seeds Persephone eats in Hades (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 140, 334). The emotional reunion between the two goddesses at the end of the hymn highlights how important Persephone's bond with her mother is: "Persephone on the other side, when she saw her mother's sweet eyes, left the chariot and horses, and leaped down to run to her, and falling upon her neck, embraced her." (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 387–90)

In his Latin poetic versions of the myth, Ovid similarly highlights the unbreakable bond between mother and daughter, firstly by depicting their grief at separation (*Met.* V. 395–400) and secondly by detailing Ceres' relentless search for Proserpina (Ov. *Fast.* IV. 480–531; Ov. *Met.* V. 439–50). In addition to scouring every corner of the upperworld in search of her (Ov. *Fast*. IV. 549–50), in the *Metamorphoses*, Ceres confronts Zeus directly, boldly asserting that it would be dishonourable for her daughter to be married to a "robber" (*Met*. V. 523).[16] Echoing Persephone's sentiments in the *Hymn to Demeter*, Proserpina's joy upon learning that she will be reunited with Ceres shows that she prefers life with Demeter in the mortal realm (Ov. *Met*. V. 569–74; Ov. *Fast*. IV. 676). The central idea in these stories remains consistent: the bond between Demeter and Persephone (mother and daughter) is incredibly strong, surpassing even the relationship between Hades and Persephone (husband and wife).

Demeter plays a central role in these texts, where her character is vividly portrayed through her actions (searching for her daughter, confronting Zeus, reuniting with Persephone) and emotional responses (mourning, lamenting, punishing, accepting). In the *Homeric Hymn*, *Metamorphoses*, and *Fasti*, she is shown as a caring and protective mother, embodying growth, fertility and nourishment. She spares no effort in her quest to bring her daughter back and guarantee her safe return. Her actions ultimately benefit Persephone, who can return to earth thanks to her mother's unwavering determination. Demeter emerges as the undisputed hero, with her love for Persephone celebrated as extraordinary and even epic.[17]

Persephone, on the other hand, remains a relatively underexplored character in classical texts, where her relationship with Hades is depicted as non-consensual. Hades seizes her while she picks flowers in a meadow, an act described with language that highlights its brutality and the devastating impact on both Persephone and her mother (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 5, 8; Ov. *Fast*. IV. 430–56; *Met.* V. 385–95). Within the context of ancient religion and society, Persephone's abduction was viewed as a necessary stage in the female life

[16]However, unlike the *Hymn to Demeter*, Ovid suggests the marriage between Proserpina and Pluto is the result of true love. Jupiter voices this romantic and male-centric perspective, defending the abduction and dismissing Demeter's objections. Jupiter goes so far as to suggest that the union is honourable, and that Proserpina should remain with her husband (*Met*. V. 523, 526–9). For an exploration of Ovid's versions of the myth as revisions of the *Hymn to Demeter*, see Foley, *Hymn to Demeter*, 149–66.

[17]Only Claudian depicts Ceres as an excessively protective mother. Claud. *Rapt. Pros.* I. 240–50. She is described as a "fierce mother" and "prouder above all mothers". When Proserpine grows into a woman and "the voice of suitors is heard throughout the palace," Ceres, who "disdains" her daughter's suitors, hides her in Sicily.

cycle. It represented a woman's transition from the innocence of girlhood (Kore) to the responsibilities of adulthood (Persephone).[18] Simultaneously, the story served as a symbolic explanation for alterations in the natural and religious realms. This is evident in the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*, where the return of Persephone to the realm of the living coincides with the arrival of spring and the establishment of the Mysteries, thus linking her abduction and changes of location to both an account of the earth's annual cycle and the genesis of a cult.[19]

The abduction episode emerged as central to the Persephone myth, deemed crucial by ancient Greek and Roman societies on the grounds of the significant information it conveyed. Classical authors showed little interest in delving into other aspects of Persephone's story, particularly her emotions, thoughts, or her rule over the Underworld.[20] Once the abduction episode has occurred, the narrative focus quickly shifts to the perspectives of other characters – her mother, husband, and father – thus leaving Persephone's own viewpoint unexamined. Contemporary authors, particularly women, have sought to address this absence, restoring her silenced voice and delving into her psychology.

In Glück's *Averno*, the daughter's struggles and concerns take centre stage; however, this does not entail relegating Demeter and Hades to secondary roles, as it often does in contemporary retellings of the myth.[21] In this reception, Demeter and Hades are key figures influencing Persephone's maturational path. Persephone's journeys from the earth to the Underworld (and back again) are used to reflect the infernal challenges young women face today. *Averno* thus raises two crucial questions: What are these challenges? Can Persephone voice them? Addressing these issues requires first situating Glück's poetry collection within the broader context of twentieth-century receptions of Graeco-Roman mythology, especially revisionist interpretations of classical myths, to which *Averno* is clearly indebted. This information will help assess the contribution of the poems discussed later, as well as the impact of Glück's work on the broader reception of the Persephone myth.

Persephone and the Feminist Appropriation of Myth: Mothers, Daughters, Violence and Change

In a seminal contribution to feminist literary criticism in the 1980s, Adrienne Rich calls for a feminist lens in approaching classical mythology to understand "the assumptions in which we are drenched".[22] This perspective lays the groundwork for a range of revisionist mythmaking in the latter half of the twentieth century. A generation of women writers emerges, committed to challenging the male-dominated frameworks that have long shaped poetic and mythical discourse. Defined as "mythopoetic revisionism",[23] this

[18]Foley, *Hymn to Demeter*, 81.
[19]Ibid., 65.
[20]On Persephone's limited role as wife of Hades and ruler of the Underworld, see Louis, *Persephone Rises*, 43–50.
[21]This is especially true in young adult retellings of the myth of Persephone, a literary genre where accounts of Persephone have only grown since the start of the twentieth century. See Salcedo González, *Persephone in Young Adult Fiction*.
[22]Rich, "Writing as Re-Vision," 18.
[23]Friedman, *Psyche Reborn*; Ostriker, *Thieves of Language*. This concept is analogous to "appropriation". Hardwick, *Reception Studies*, 9.

movement shapes a distinct "women's literary tradition" and inspires gendered interpretations of the Persephone myth, mainly in the English-speaking world.[24] These texts, produced across various disciplines, become catalysts for delving into three themes of major importance to feminism in the 1980s: the mother-daughter bond, gender-based violence and women's transitions through life phases.[25]

Within the topic of female bonds, two approaches characterise the revisionist treatment of the Demeter-Persephone relationship. One idealises Demeter's strength and devotion by portraying maternal love as an antidote to the suffering inflicted on Persephone by Zeus and Hades. Rich's *Of Woman Born* (1976) exemplifies this perspective, as do poems such as Harriet Zinnes's "Demeter to Persephone" (1967), Kate Ellis's "Matrilineal Descent" (1980), and Enid Dame's "Persephone" (1985), which celebrate maternal power and the mother-daughter bond as a form of resistance. A contrasting reading highlights the tensions in this relationship and depict Demeter's overprotective love as an obstacle to Persephone's independence. This is seen in poems by Carolyn Kizer ("Persephone Pauses", 1984), Nan Fry ("From Persephone's Letters to Demeter", 1991) and Rita Dove (*Mother Love*, 1995).[26]

A second group of interpretations foregrounds the theme of abduction as a critique of sexual violence. Scholars in psychotherapy and feminist theory such as Mary Daly (1978) and Phyllis Chesler (1972) examine the psychological toll of such violence, while Annis Pratt (1994) argues that the repeated narrative of Persephone's abduction, and the fact that there is no hopeful reading of it, reinforces the victimisation of women and limits possibilities for empowerment. These insights inform literary reinterpretations like Alison Stone's "Persephone's First Season in Hell" (1992) and Carol Ann Duffy's "Demeter" (1999), both of which portray the devastating impact of Persephone's rape on her and her mother. Jenny Joseph's poetry collection *Persephone* (1986) broadens this theme to expose patterns of violence against women across various historical and cultural contexts.[27]

Psychological interpretations of the Persephone myth view it as a symbolic rite of passage, with Kore representing the younger dimension of a woman's unconscious and Demeter embodying maturity.[28] Under this perspective, psychotherapist Eleanor Hall (1980) suggests that Hades, read metaphorically, plays a positive role in Persephone's growth by awakening her to her sexuality and fertility (see also Woolger and Barker 1987). These psychoanalytic interpretations resonate in literary works such as Alicia Ostriker's "Demeter to Persephone" (1937), where Persephone must separate from her mother to uncover a more wholesome version of her identity. Similarly, Eavan Boland's "The Pomegranate" (1994) shifts the focus to Demeter, who grapples

[24]Gubar, "Mother, Maiden and Death," 310.
[25]Salcedo González, *Persephone in Young Adult Fiction*, 42–7.
[26]All the examples in this section are taken from ibid., 43–6.
[27]Ibid., 43–5.
[28]Carl Gustav Jung famously argues that Kore and Demeter represent complementary aspects of the female psyche, with every woman containing both the mother and daughter within herself: "Demeter and Kore, mother and daughter, extend the feminine consciousness both upwards and downwards. They add an 'older and younger', 'stronger and weaker' dimension to it and widen out the narrowly limited conscious mind bound in space and time, giving it intimations of a greater and more comprehensive personality which has a share in the eternal course of things" (Jung, *Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious*, 185).

with the recognition that she must relinquish her younger self and embrace her identity as "older and stronger".[29]

Drawing from both ancient and modern interpretations of the Persephone myth, *Averno* "appropriates" the original tale to critique systemic oppression against women and affirm a sense of shared experience of girlhood. In the following section, I study six poems from *Averno*, identifying the various infernos Glück exposes and illustrating how they reflect the challenges faced by young women. I also examine the reception strategies she employs to advance this reading. These include hybrid reading (a), meta-mythology (b), playful use of sources (c), inversion of conventional meanings (d), and feminist appropriation (e).

Glück weaves together classical and contemporary interpretations of the Persephone myth (strategy a: hybrid reading), building on both the original accounts discussed in the previous section and the modern trends outlined here. To present and merge these ideas, she often includes erudite comments about myth, poetry, and the poet's role. These meta-poetic comments underscore the fictional nature of all stories, including myths, and challenge the privileging of any single version (strategy b: meta-mythology). In keeping with this questioning of fixed narratives, Glück reimagines the myth's structure, selectively including or omitting key episodes (strategy c: playful use of sources). This interplay of presences and absences allows her to subvert traditional meanings associated with the Persephone myth (strategy d: inversion of conventional meanings). In Glück's retelling, the earth itself becomes a hostile force – another inferno – and Demeter harms Persephone as much as Hades does in the classical accounts of the story. Ultimately, Persephone's perspective is foregrounded. Her problems are treated with empathy and solidarity, shedding light on the unique challenges faced by daughters (strategy e: feminist appropriation).

Infernos Exposed in Louise Glück's *Averno*: Persephone as Echo, Wanderer and Stranger

Structured in two parts, *Averno* intersperses poems about the tale of Persephone with meta-poetic commentary, often weaving these elements together within the same piece. Through Glück's interjections of scholarly commentary, the volume explores themes of perspective, voice, and the poet's role. These reflections, scattered in a non-linear and initially obscure manner, coalesce into a coherent poetic vision as the reader progresses through the work.[30]

The opening poem, "October",[31] introduces the collection's overarching aim and the poet's task: to speak the truth and address "the bland misery of the world".[32] This prompts key questions central to the work: How can this truth be conveyed? From what perspective should it be told? Whose voice should narrate it – the author's or another's? While many poems in *Averno* are about Persephone, not all are spoken in her voice. When Persephone is not the speaker, an omniscient third-person voice

[29]Salcedo González, *Persephone in Young Adult Fiction*, 46.
[30]Morris, *Thematic Introduction*, 12, identifies commentary as a recurring theme in Glück's poetry. For an overview of Glück's metafictional and postmodern strategies in her poetry collections, see ibid.
[31]This long six-part lyric poem was first published as a stand-alone chapbook in 2004.
[32]Glück, *Averno*, 13. All quotations from Glück's poetry collection *Averno* refer to the 2021 Penguin edition.

steps in, observing her experiences and retrieving her memories and thoughts. Occasionally, a Demeter-like voice appears, typically in the closing poems of the collection. This voice represents Kore's grown self, a later phase in a woman's life as described in archetypal theory (see Jung in the section above).

For Glück, the position and space from which one speaks and writes are crucial (as reflected in her meditations on vertical journeys). The collection's title itself signals this concern. In "October", the speaker recalls her youthful years, likely mirroring Glück's own, when she was beginning to write and routinely travelled by underground (referred to as a "tunnel"[33]). At that time, she carried a book under her arm "as though to defend myself against / this same world".[34] Literature is both the spade and talisman the poet uses to face uncomfortable truths and shield herself from the harshness and isolation of the world. In the poem's conclusion, the poem itself assumes a voice and responds to the speaker, offering consolation: "*you are not alone*, / the poem said, / in the dark tunnel".[35]

A metaphor for the Underworld, the tunnel is depicted as "dark" and might therefore elicit fear and unease in those who inhabit such a space. Yet it is precisely in this place, in that shared experience of truth-telling, that connection with others emerges and isolation is mitigated. The Underworld is envisioned here as the site from which poets must speak if their work is to leave a meaningful or consoling impression.[36] Glück's conception of the Underworld as a metaphorical space for poetic truth aligns with a broader literary tradition that gained prominence at the turn of the twentieth century, when the idea of the Underworld shifted from a physical location to an internal, psychological state.[37] This modern understanding of the Underworld as both a psychological and social reality ensures its enduring relevance and facilitates its later reuse by authors like Glück, who view it as a site for poetic and existential exploration.

One of the most revealing insights into the author's poetic mission comes in the title poem, "Averno",[38] which appears near the end of the collection. Here, the speaker, an experienced older woman on the verge of death, reflects on life and seeks to impart the lessons she has gained. She recognises first the illusions of safety and stability, declaring: "They're living in a dream, and I'm preparing / to be a ghost. I want to shout out / the mist has cleared – / It's like some new life."[39] An informed reading of the entire work makes it reasonable to interpret this speaker as a Demeter-like figure, someone who has endured the experiences of Persephone and now desires to share her wisdom, particularly with young women. The following sections will further develop this reading,

[33]Ibid., 13.
[34]Ibid.
[35]Ibid., 14 (emphasis by the author).
[36]"October" may be read as a spiritual exercise. In fact, the entire collection *Averno* has been interpreted as the author's "*via negativa*", "her account of a Dark Night of the Soul akin to that written by St. John of the Cross". Morris, *Thematic Introduction*, 12.
[37]López Gregoris, "Itinerarios por las literaturas occidentales," 13. This shift is evident in the works of the cursed poets – Arthur Rimbaud and Charles Baudelaire – and the ascetic Oscar Wilde (*De Profundis*, 1905), as well as modernist and contemporary writers like T. S. Eliot (*The Waste Land*, 1922) and Don DeLillo (*Underworld*, 1997) (ibid., 13). These authors explore Hades as a source of personal transformation, psychological truth, and a space for confronting difficult realities. In a similar vein, Falconer argues that the Underworld reflects "the modern condition", providing a compelling motif for articulating the anxieties of the twentieth century. Falconer, *Hell in Contemporary Literature*, 73–200.
[38]Glück, *Averno*, 60–9.
[39]Ibid., 61.

but in this poem, the speaker, for instance, responds to young girls' concerns about their safety:

> Some young girls ask me / if they'll be safe near Averno – / they're cold, they want to go south a little while. / And one says, like a joke, but not too far south – / I say, as safe as anywhere, / which makes them happy. / What it means is nothing is safe.[40]

In this poem and elsewhere in the book the eponymous metaphor represents the dangerous spaces and situations that young women must face as they grow up. Averno is not a place or situation which can be pinpointed; rather, these "infernal experiences" take various forms and permeate many aspects of a woman's life, as implied by the Demeterian speaker's line, "nothing is safe".[41] The poem further fleshes this notion out, describing how these spaces shape young women's lives:

> You get on a train, you disappear.
> You write your name on the window, you disappear.
> There are places like this everywhere,
> places you enter as a young girl,
> from which you never return
> ...
> Something within the night
> exposed now –.[42]

Because the speaker was a girl before she became a woman, she is familiar with the infernal experiences common in girlhood and can now point them out for others to learn from ("Something within the night / exposed now –"[43]). The transformation implied in this poem – from Persephone (the youthful aspect) to Demeter (the mature aspect) – is grounded in psychological readings of the myth, particularly Jungian analysis of the Kore archetype, which investigates how the earth-mother figure emerges through a lived understanding of the daughter's trials.[44] In this poem, and in others throughout the poetic sequence (see "Prism" in the section below), the mother's personal familiarity with the dangers of girlhood enables her to offer guidance and solidarity to others. This solidarity with other "Persephones" lies at the heart of Glück's reinterpretation of the myth.

In the subsequent discussion, I will demonstrate how Glück "appropriates" the Persephone myth to expose various oppressive forces that render women echoes of themselves, wanderers without desire, and strangers to both the world and their own identities.

Persephone: The Echo

In addition to introducing the themes of perspective and poetry's function, "October" starts Glück's exploration of girls' infernal experiences, mapped onto Persephone's descent into the Underworld and interpreted through the prism of myth. Using the

[40]Ibid., 64.
[41]Ibid.
[42]Ibid.
[43]Ibid.
[44]*Averno* treats Persephone as mythological material, but also as archetypal matter. In this line, Gosmann has argued that, by explaining the manifestations of the Kore archetype, "Glück's poems enact the process of individuation as described by Jung. The space of the poem is ... the analytic space." "Psychoanalyzing Persephone," 220, 226. Gosmann's reading suggests that Glück's book is more than a spiritual exercise: it is a therapy session.

voice of a Persephone-like figure, the poem delivers a fragmented testimony of these torments, skilfully tweaking the speaker's voice to make a case about the disorientation and vulnerability experienced by young women. The poem opens with a troubled, confused poetic persona who repeatedly asks unanswered questions: "is it winter again, is it cold again / ... / didn't the night end, / didn't the melting ice / flood the narrow gutters / ... / didn't we plant the seeds".[45] The reiteration of these inquiries, met only with silence, suggests a cyclical entrapment in anguish and pain, recalling Persephone's annual return to Hades and forced separation from her mother (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 40; *Met.* V. 395–400). The poem also parallels Echo's fate in Book III of Ovid's *Metamorphoses,* where she is cursed to regurgitate the words of others, losing her own voice. In both cases, repetition leads to a loss of self: these women are unable to break free from the words they are compelled to say, defined now by their acts of compulsion.

Of particular note in "October" is the poetic voice's inability to articulate the source of her trauma. As Caruth explains, trauma resists expression in ordered discourse.[46] What reaches the reader are fragmented memories and impressions. The lyrical "I" speaks from a kind of hell. Though the exact nature of her distress remains undefined, recurring images of the body, the wound and the scar suggest an experience of physical violence: "wasn't my body / rescued, wasn't it safe / didn't the scar form, invisible / above the injury / terror and cold".[47] The abrupt line breaks[48] mirror the dislocation of the speaker – both body and mind – evoking a sense of rupture and suddenness akin to the speed and brusqueness with which Hades burst forth to cart Persephone off in an instant (see the descriptions of the abduction in the *Hymn to Demeter* and Ovid).

The following lines in the poem allude directly to Persephone's and her mother's traditional roles as goddesses of agriculture and the cycle of nature: "didn't the night end, / wasn't the earth / Safe when it was planted / Didn't we plant the seeds, / Weren't we necessary to the earth".[49] Here, Persephone wonders why the things that were supposed to be fixed from long ago no longer happen. She wonders why life has become threatening for her and her mother, why planting the earth no longer guarantees their safety, as it used to in the past. The speaker points to some of the myth's key episodes and themes – the cycle of the seasons, the reunion of mother and daughter, the arrival of spring – but only to note their absence. The poem selectively omits crucial moments of the original myth (strategy c), subverting its usual meanings (strategy d) to present a world where renewal and reunion are no longer assured. As the poem unfolds, it becomes clear that Persephone and Demeter will not experience a joyful reunion, nor will they enjoy an idyllic time on earth during the warm seasons, and spring will no longer offer the hope and security it once did (see *Hom. Hym. Dem.* 401–5; Ov. *Met.* V. 642).

In section 2 of "October", the poetic voice provides additional insight into why the natural pattern of things is broken:

[45]Glück, *Averno*, 5–6.
[46]Caruth, *Unclaimed Experience*, 20. For a study of Glück's engagement with trauma theory and the question of witness in *Averno* and her other poetry collections, see Morris, *Thematic Introduction*, 98–138.
[47]Glück, *Averno*, 5.
[48]Glück's compositional style, with its short lines and strong breaks, obscures the poem's meaning at first. Only by piecing together these scattered elements can readers grasp the full weight of the speaker's experience. This technique recalls the modernist poetics of William Carlos Williams, to whom Glück has acknowledged a clear debt. See Raffel, "Poetry of Louise Glück," 270.
[49]Glück, *Averno*, 6.

Summer after summer has ended,
balm after violence:
it does me no good
to be good to me now;
violence has changed me.
...
the August sun, returns
everything that was taken away
Once more, the sun rises as it rose in summer;
bounty, balm after violence.[50]

The phrase "balm after violence" portrays summer as a time of rest and optimism, yet the speaker subverts this comforting image, declaring that "it does me no good / to be good to me now; / violence has changed me".[51] In this way, the poem disrupts the belief that Persephone's return to earth compensates for her forced life in the Underworld (strategy d: inversion of conventional meanings).[52] The speaker's psyche remains fractured; there is no true recovery. The repetition of thoughts, unanswered questions, and fragmented memories throughout the poem are testament to the speaker's everlastingly disoriented, trauma-stricken mind.

The notion of change is at the core of the myth of Persephone. Kore (the girl) becomes Persephone (the woman) after her abduction by Hades, just as winter transitions into spring upon her return to the earth each year. The implication is that the cycle (of the seasons, of womanhood ...) depends on Persephone's periodic absence.[53] In *Averno*, Glück revises the notion of change and offers an uncomfortable meaning. Tapping into ecofeminist theory, she reframes Persephone's journeys (and hence suffering) as a disruption rather than a justification of natural order.[54] Persephone's trauma is mirrored in the natural world, implying a connection between personal and ecological harm: "It does me no good; violence has changed me. / My body has grown cold like the stripped fields; / now there is only my mind, cautious and wary; / with the sense it is being tested."[55] By the poem's conclusion, despair takes hold as the speaker acknowledges the cycle of violence will persist: "Tell me this is the future, / I won't believe you. / Tell me I am living, / I won't believe you."[56] The violence inflicted on Persephone in "October" is not framed as a necessary initiation into womanhood, nor as a precondition for the cycle of nature to function. Rather than justifying or explaining violence, Glück uses Persephone's voice to lay bare its devastating and lasting effects.[57]

[50]Ibid., 7.
[51]Ibid.
[52]In the *Hymn to Demeter*, for example, Persephone's return brings relief and renewal, particularly to Demeter, who ends her period of grief and allows the earth to become fertile again. The idea that balance has been restored is foregrounded. The people of Eleusis are also content, as Demeter teaches them the secret rites of her worship, which promise blessings in life and the afterlife (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 471–95). Very little is revealed about Persephone's own feelings about her fate.
[53]Foley, *Hymn to Demeter*, 65.
[54]Gordon has linked Glück's work to ecofeminism, describing her poetics as "rooted in the biological, psychological, and spiritual experience of being a woman – a daughter, a sister, a lover, and a mother – in late-twentieth-century America". Gordon, *Louise Glück and Postmodern Spirituality*, 2.
[55]Glück, *Averno*, 7.
[56]Ibid., 8.
[57]Toni Morrison's *The Bluest Eye* (1970) has also been studied as an ecofeminist reading of the myth of Persephone. See Gubar, "Mother, Maiden and Death." Another example in this line is Laurie Sheck's poem "The Book of Persephone" (1996).

Glück's interaction with the myth of Persephone is sustained through a deliberate tension between absence and presence (strategy c: playful use of sources). Notably, the mythic episode of Persephone's abduction is absent in "October"; we are not explicitly told what happens to her. We only know the consequences. Without a clear cause, there is no way to link the event to an idea of renewal or change – this possibility is discarded from the outset. By stripping away these narrative pillars, the author underscores the arbitrariness of the violence against Persephone, a senselessness that cannot be explained and therefore cannot be justified or naturalised (strategy d: inversion of conventional meanings; strategy e: feminist appropriation).[58]

Persephone: The Wanderer

Two poems that offer key insight into the various infernos Glück exposes – and the scope of her social critique through the lens of the Underworld – are "Persephone the Wanderer" (1) and "Persephone the Wanderer" (2). "Wanderer" (1) appears early in the collection as the second poem of Part I. Here, the interpretation of the myth is more ambiguous, partly because the reception strategies used heighten the fictional nature of the Persephone story, thereby questioning the possibility of conclusive readings. In contrast, "Wanderer" (2) presents a more defined psychological profile of the characters, closing off the amplitude of readings to a more univocal understanding of the story – perhaps because, as the final poem in *Averno*, it serves as a more definitive response to the questions raised in "Wanderer" (1).

In terms of structure, these poems frame Persephone's spiritual journey, which begins in the world of the living in "Wanderer" (1), leads into the Underworld (the poems in between "Wanderer" 1 and 2), and ends with the announcement of her rebirth and return to the earth in "Wanderer" (2). As Gosmann observes, they function as "gateways marking the entrance into the Underworld and the exit from it".[59] The issue, however, is that unlike in the classical versions of the myth, Persephone's return to earth in *Averno* does not lead to her inner rebirth or the restoration of hope, since, in Glück's portrayal, life with Demeter on earth constitutes another form of inferno. Let us now see how this reading is activated in the poems.

In "Wanderer" (1), the speaker adopts a philological tone and register, probably a projection of Glück's own voice, and references "versions"[60] of the Persephone story, both classical and contemporary. She also revisits questions about the myth that scholars – and classical authors – have long debated, while also criticising their lack of sensitivity in how they approach the abduction episode. This critique is evident in lines such as:

> Persephone's initial / sojourn in hell continues to be / pawed over by scholars who dispute / the sensations of the virgin: / did she cooperate in her rape, / or was she drugged, violated against her will, / as happens so often now to modern girls.[61]

[58]This poem, and *Averno* as a whole, builds on revisionist readings of the Persephone myth popularised in the second half of the twentieth century. Jenny Joseph (*Persephone*, 1986) and Alison Stone ("Persephone's First Season in Hell," 1992) strip Persephone's abduction of its explanatory or legitimising function – no connection is made to seasonal change or the agricultural cycle. What remains is the brutal aftermath of violence.

[59]Gosmann, "Psychoanalyzing Persephone," 222.

[60]The two "Persephone the Wanderer" poems are described as a "first version" (Glück, *Averno*, 16) and a "second version" (ibid., 73). Glück is adding up her versions of the myth to the ongoing tradition of Persephone readings.

[61]Ibid., 16.

The dispute mentioned in these lines traces back to the classical sources' contrasting accounts of Persephone's degree of cooperation in eating the pomegranate seeds that bind her to the Underworld.[62] This ambiguity has become a focal point in interpretations of the myth from the Middle Ages to the present. Glück's engagement in this "meta-mythological"[63] reflection (strategy b) reveals her deep familiarity with both the classical sources and their afterlives. It also underlines her understanding of the Persephone myth (and mythology in general) as a literary construct shaped and reshaped through scholarly and authorial curation.

The speaker's erudition in this section of the poem establishes her as an authoritative voice, one who appears to know everything (an omniscient speaker) and is conveniently uninvolved (a reliable and objective speaker). However, this sense of detachment is broken at various points throughout "Wanderer" (1 and 2), as the speaker merges with Persephone's voice, shifting from the third person to the first-person "I". As noted in the analysis of "October" and "Averno", Glück adopts various subject positions, including those of the poet (in both young and old versions), Persephone and Demeter. These shifts add to the elusive quality of the lyrical voice, casting doubt on the reliability of what is being relayed.[64]

Having pointed to different interpretations (strategy a: hybrid reading), the speaker indicates her preferred (modern) reading of the myth, which she explicates in detail: Persephone, Demeter and Hades are not people, but "aspects of a dilemma or conflict".[65] The conflict primarily affects and hurts Persephone, who is "a born wanderer",[66] forever obligated to drift aimlessly between Hades and Demeter. This is the poem's key theme (and Persephone's dilemma). As Glück writes:

> The terrible reunions in store for her
> will take up the rest of her life.
> when the passion for expiation
> is chronic, fierce, you do not choose
> the way you live. You do not live;
> you are not allowed to die.
>
> You drift between earth and death
> which seems, finally,
> strangely alike.[67]

[62]In most sources, Hades deceives Persephone when he feeds her a pomegranate seed with the intention of keeping her in the underworld permanently (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 372, 412–13; Apollod. *Lib*. I. 5, 3; II. 5, 12). In Ovid's accounts (*Met*. V. 537; *Fast*. IV. 667–8), it is Proserpina herself, not Pluto, who picks the fruit from a tree without awareness of consequences. The *Hymn to Demeter* presents two conflicting versions of the episode. The first, narrated by the speaker (371–2), depicts Persephone willingly accepting the food offered by Hades. The second version, recounted by Persephone to her mother after their reunion (412–13), contradicts the narrator's account. Persephone emphasises Hades' violence and portrays eating the fruit as involuntary. Critics have viewed this inconsistency as either a narrative flaw or a deliberate lie by Persephone, possibly as a means of justifying herself to her mother. Torres Guerra, *Himno a Deméter*, 108.

[63]"Meta-mythology" or "self-conscious" mythology is an emblem of postmodern writing. It refers to when mythical characters reflect on their own myths or when myths are presented in a self-conscious manner, emphasising the fictional quality of myth and indicating that it is being discussed in the capacity of fiction rather than real life. Wright, *Euripides' Escape-Tragedies*, 133–57.

[64]For an insightful analysis of the poem's fluid and playful manipulation of speakers and other postmodernist techniques, see Kichouh Aiadi, "Louise Glück's 'Persephone the Wanderer'," 72.

[65]Glück, *Averno*, 17.

[66]Ibid.

[67]Ibid., 18.

The adjective "wanderer" in the title reinforces this idea of displacement and restlessness, a chronic condition for Persephone, who "will take up the rest of her life" in this state. Glück gives her a new epithet, departing from the traditional titles of "The one with the delicate ankles", "flower-faced girl", "the most beautiful" (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 2, 8. 493), "Ceres's daughter" (Ov. *Met.* V. 384) and "the girl" (Ov. *Met.* V. 424). The Persephone of *Averno* resembles a female Odysseus[68]: restless and rootless, with no true home or place of belonging (see earlier discussion on summer, spring and Glück's subversion of their conventional associations).

Glück explores the psychological and archetypal reasons behind Persephone's wandering status throughout the poem[69]:

> Scholars tell us / that there is no point in knowing what you want / when the forces contending over you / could kill you. / ... / ... the tale of Persephone / ... should be read / as an argument between the mother and the lover–/ the daughter is just meat.[70]

In this reading, Persephone, Demeter and Hades are archetypes: they represent the contending forces within an argument of intense emotions.[71] Persephone's struggles are paradigmatic: the girl caught between her mother and her lover, forced to wander two realms and torn between competing commitments and affections. These obligations – daughter to Demeter, wife to Hades – confine her to a life dictated by the expectations and demands of others, ultimately relegating her to the status of a "wanderer" rather than a traveller; travelling, after all, implies choice and the freedom to chart one's own path.

Persephone's aimlessness is most evident in Glück's retelling of the classical abduction episode. Distinct from the original sources, where Persephone's rape by Hades is unequivocally portrayed as something she did not want (see *Hom. Hym. Dem.* 5, 8; Ov. *Fast.* IV. 430–56; *Met.* V. 385–95; Claud. *Rapt. Pros.* II. 75–80), in "Wanderer" (1), Persephone does not actively resist Hades. Instead, she simply does not know what she wants. When the god appears to claim her, she allows it to happen thoughtlessly and aimlessly,[72] since "there is no point in knowing what you want / when the forces contending over you / could kill you".[73] These lines encapsulate the essence of Persephone's tragedy: she is denied the time and space necessary to discover her desires, to understand her actions, and to grow into her own person. Deprived of these opportunities, she remains an eternal victim, uncertain about every aspect of life. Glück reimagines the abduction episode, often reduced to the question of whether Persephone consented, into a more nuanced exploration of her capacity to understand her situation at all.

[68]Homer describes Odysseus' wandering with phrases that convey relentless movement and displacement, such as **πολύτροπος** (*polytropos*, "of many turns") and **πολύπλαγχτος** (*polýplankhtos*, "much-wandering" or "driven about"). See *Od.* I.1–2.

[69]Persephone's wanderings in this poem find a correlation – encouraged by the near homophony of "wander" and "wonder" – in the poem discussed earlier, "October", where Persephone wonders repeatedly about her situation and, in a sense, her mind wanders and is restless due to the consequences of trauma.

[70]Glück, *Averno*, 18–19.

[71]As Glück herself has confirmed, her work lends itself easily to a psychoanalytical reading, given her training as an analyst.

[72]When Hades "confronts her, she has never seen / the meadow without the daisies. / Suddenly she is no longer / singing her maidenly songs / about her mother's / beauty and fecundity". Glück, *Averno*, 19. Persephone does not even register what has happened: she was in the meadow perplexed about Hades' presence there and how he changes the surroundings, and suddenly she is in the Underworld doing something else.

[73]Ibid., 18.

At the end of the poem, a first-person voice – that of Persephone herself – takes over and challenges readers to step in her own shoes and face her dilemma: "What will you do, / when it is your turn in the field with the god?".[74] Through this powerful and unsettling question, Glück exposes the constraints that hinder girls' ability to assert themselves, delving into contemporary issues of consent and agency and generating more questions than answers (strategy d: inversion of conventional meanings; strategy e: feminist appropriation): Can we expect a refusal from someone who does not yet understand what is happening to her? Without a support system? Does it even matter if a girl says yes or no when she lacks the awareness to fully grasp the implications of her situation?

One of the most striking ingredients of "Wanderer" (1) is that, in contrast to the *Hymn to Demeter* (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 387–90) or Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (V. 569–74), Persephone is not happy to return to Demeter. In fact, she was already discontented with her life on earth alongside her mother: " ... Regarding / incarceration, she believes / she has been a prisoner since she has been a daughter."[75] Persephone's life with Demeter (and the possibility of reuniting with her) is as much an inferno for Persephone as the Underworld itself. This idea is fully-fledged in "Persephone the Wanderer" (2), where the speaker pits Persephone's experience against Demeter's, transforming their relationship into one of opposition:

> [Persephone] is going to know, really,
> only two adults: death and her mother.
> But two is
> twice what her mother has:
> her mother has one child, a daughter.
> ...
> We begin to see here
> the deep violence of the earth
> whose hostility suggests
> she has no wish
> to continue as a source of life.[76]

In this poem, the traditional depiction of Demeter as a nurturing earth mother acting in Persephone's best interest is radically inverted (strategy d: inversion of conventional meanings). Indeed, Demeter is described as a source of death and the primary reason Persephone becomes a "born wanderer" ("Now over and over / her mother hauls her out again –"[77]). The speaker even asserts that Demeter's actions after her daughter's disappearance are not driven by the motivations attributed to her in classical sources. The *Hymn to Demeter* and Ovid's *Metamorphoses* tell us that Demeter roams the earth to rescue Persephone, who has been taken against her will and is writhing in the Underworld. In these accounts, Demeter punishes the world without crops to force Zeus to intervene and arrange the daughter's return (*Hom. Hym. Dem.* 305–14; Ov. *Met.* V. 474–86). Glück's retelling presents a far grimmer scenario for Persephone. While Demeter does wander the earth, she does so not to punish the gods or the world, but her own daughter.

[74]Ibid., 19.
[75]Ibid., 18.
[76]Ibid., 74.
[77]Ibid., 76.

Persephone is the target of Demeter's fury in this account of the myth. The mother's wandering becomes "a warning whose implicit message is: / *what are you doing outside my body?*".[78] For Demeter, Persephone does not exist, except as a "branch" of her body that "needs to be reattached at any cost".[79] Notably, both mother and daughter are described as "wanderers", a deliberate choice by the author: Persephone wanders between Demeter and Hades, while Demeter wanders the earth searching for her daughter. Persephone's wandering reflects her mother's own, demonstrating how a parent's behaviours can shape a child's path. Glück's reinterpretation of Demeter's role is informed by her complex relationship with her mother. In her autobiographical essay "Education of the Poet", the author describes how her mother dominated conversations, stifling her voice, and served as her harshest critic.[80] Yet her mother also read to her constantly, so that by the age of three, she was already "well grounded in the Greek myths", with their characters becoming central reference points in her imagination.[81]

Glück's view of Persephone and Demeter is deeply tied to her early introduction to mythology, as well as to the personal memory of her mother and their fraught relationship.[82] Building on the myth of Persephone, *Averno* addresses family drama and interpersonal dynamics: the author's ambivalent and troubled connections with both mother and lover. As Morris notes, "Allusiveness enables [Glück] to be elusive; to at once reveal and hide the speaker's vulnerabilities through the distance afforded by referring to myths and sources".[83] Myth thus becomes a protective mask; it allows Glück to approach painful autobiographical material at a remove. In this way, she achieves to transform trying episodes of her life into a narrative of mythic and general resonance.[84]

Returning to the "dilemma" introduced in "Wanderer" (1), the conflict in this poem is more clearly framed insofar as the responsibility is placed almost entirely on Demeter. The tone towards her is more accusatory, with the earth depicted as a place where Persephone has no desire to remain under any circumstances. In the poem's closing lines, Persephone's voice is heard again as she pleads with her father, asking how she is to "endure the earth".[85] Zeus reassures her by saying that she will return to the Underworld, an ironic nod to the *Hymn to Demeter*, where Zeus appeases Demeter by confirming that Persephone will return to earth each year. As with other aspects of the myth, Glück slightly alters the events described in the original story (strategy c) – here, it is the daughter, not Demeter, who appeals to Zeus – resulting in a radical reversal of meaning (strategy d): the daughter resists life on earth, Zeus becomes a source of comfort, and Demeter is cast as the antagonist.[86]

The reception of the myth in "Wanderer" (2) is in line with the modern and postmodern tendency to imagine a conflict between Persephone and Demeter, one that is caused

[78]Ibid., 75 (emphasis by the author).
[79]Ibid.
[80]Glück, "Essays on Poetry," 5.
[81]Ibid., 7.
[82]Gosmann, "Psychoanalyzing Persephone," 235.
[83]Morris, *Thematic Introduction*, 31.
[84]Glück's poetry has been classified as American postconfessional poetry. For an analysis of Glück's postconfessionalism and the role of myth in this context, see Morris, "'Poems Are Autobiography' Toward Imagining a Postconfessionalist's Biography," 21–35. For a more recent contribution to the discussion, see Baker, "Versions of Ascesis in Louise Glück's Poetry" and Bartczak, "The Paradigm of the Void: Louise Glück's Post-Confessional Deadlock."
[85]Glück, *Averno*, 76.
[86]On Demeter's "reductive" portrayal as a jealous woman in Glück's *Averno*, see Hurst, "Autumnal Underworld," esp. 78.

primarily by the mother's overprotectiveness. Authors like Rita Dove (*Mother Love*, 1995) emphasise Persephone's struggles with certain controlling aspects of Demeter's personality, as well as their difficulty in achieving fluid and sincere communication. In "Wanderer" (2), Demeter's perception of her daughter as merely an extension of her body – "a branch" to be reattached – echoes the constant tensions in Dove's *Mother Love*, where Demeter journeys to Paris, the book's Underworld, in an effort to persuade her daughter to leave Hades. When they finally meet, mother and daughter cannot see eye to eye; reaching an understanding is out of the question. This notion of disconnect also finds resonance in the retellings by Carolyn Kizer and Nan Fry, both of whom probe the generational and emotional divides that create friction in mother-daughter relationships.[87]

Departing from the idealised portrayals of maternal devotion in the *Hymn to Demeter* and the *Metamorphoses*, or even in modern reinterpretations by Adrienne Rich and Enid Dame, Glück describes mother-daughter relationships in a more intricate and critical manner. Her approach brings attention to a seldom-discussed aspect of Persephone's experience: the dual sources of oppression in her life. While Hades' authoritarian claim over her is undeniable, her family's demands, particularly her mother's, are equally constraining. Glück's narrative lays bare the systemic pressures on women – not just from external, patriarchal forces but also from internal familial expectations. By shifting the focus to the daughter's perspective, the younger, more vulnerable side, Glück not only revises traditional depictions of the mother-daughter bond but also broadens and complicates the conversation about this relationship for modern readers.

Persephone: The Stranger

In "Prism" (Part I of *Averno*), one of the collection's most incisive poems, the poet continues her critique of the pressures imposed on young women as they grow up and the impact of such demands on their lives. The first-person speaker is directly involved in the events described: a woman reflects on her own marriage and recalls how it was discussed at home by her mother and sisters. In this recollection, "falling in love" and "marrying" are stripped of romanticism and reframed as obligatory "assignments" that girls are expected to complete as part of their passage to adulthood.[88] Using a scholarly and detached tone (see in this same line "Wanderer" 1), the speaker approaches this reality with the precision of a linguist, dissecting the cultural codes embedded in the language of marriage:

> the implication was, it was necessary to abandon
> childhood. The word "marry" was a signal.
> You could also treat it as aesthetic device;
> ...
> The word was a code, mysterious, like the Rosetta stone.
> It was also a roadsign, a warning.[89]

[87]For a study of these and other poetic representations of the mother-daughter bond in English literature, see Adams, "Maternal Bonds."
[88]Glück, *Averno*, 22.
[89]Ibid.

This postmodern dissection of language reveals marriage as a site of quiet violence and personal erasure, particularly for women: "You could take a few things with you like a dowry. / You could take the part of you that thought. / 'Marry' meant you should keep that part quite."[90] The poem presents marriage as a structure that demands the suppression of independent thought. The lyrical "I"'s matter-of-fact tone expresses resignation and acceptance, implying that women's say in such decisions is limited even today. The underlying idea is that the violence of silence and submission still lurks beneath the surface of seemingly mundane social rituals. This depiction resonates with the context of Persephone's marriage to Hades and the broader realities of marriage for women in Antiquity. Ancient Greek women often had little to no agency in choosing their husbands. The story of Persephone testifies to this: her union with Hades is orchestrated by Zeus and Hades without her consent or that of her mother (see esp. Ovid). While classical audiences may have perceived Persephone's fate as inevitable or even natural,[91] Glück's poem provocatively links this ancient framework to modern situations and structures, exposing their shared reliance on the restriction and policing of girls' autonomy. The poem suggests that the violence entrenched in marriage – whether in Antiquity or today – is rooted in longstanding patriarchal ideologies.

The figure speaking in "Prism" is more than just a modern woman reflecting on marriage; she is a Demeter-like figure whose authority stems from her understanding of Persephone in an archetypal sense (in this line, see also "Averno"). The speaker in "Prism" reflects this dual perspective: just as Kore becomes Persephone and later Demeter, the speaker's familiarity with the infernal experiences of girlhood allows her to expose these patterns for others to recognise and resist. Crucially, because she speaks from Averno – the portal to Hades – and has been down there, she possesses a hard-won insight into patriarchal violence, the structures of power and control, and the cost of surviving these structures ("Something within the night / exposed now –"[92]).

The poem further emphasises women's lack of agency in marriage through the image of lightning striking young women as they grow up, leaving them "wired forever to your true love".[93] This lightning evokes Zeus' symbolic lightning bolt, an emblem of his immense power and authority. In Greek mythology, Zeus frequently misuses this power in his non-consensual pursuits of women, making the lightning in "Prism" a chilling metaphor for the numbing effects of marriage and societal and familial expectations. Once struck, women are left paralysed, disconnected from their own desires and uncertain about how to act. This parallels the moment in "Wanderer" (1) when Persephone succumbs to Hades without resistance, not because she consents, but because she has yet to learn what she wants, or perhaps even fails to grasp what is happening to her. Similarly, in "Wanderer" (2), Persephone is pulled by Demeter frantically and compulsively: the mother wants her daughter for herself. This shows that Demeter and Hades are opposing but equally powerful, death-driven forces, contending over Persephone's fate. The lightning and the hauling symbolise this struggle and reinforce the idea that Persephone's life is defined by forces beyond her control.

[90]Ibid.
[91]Foley, *Hymn to Demeter*, 50.
[92]Glück, *Averno*, 64.
[93]Ibid., 24.

In "Prism", the lighting is depicted as both "intelligent" and "potent", targeting girls as they begin to experience the world. Reflecting on this life-changing moment, the speaker observes:

> You grew up, you were struck by lighting
> When you opened your eyes, you were wired forever to your true love.
> It only happened once. Then you were taken care of,
> Your story was finished.[94]

The lightning strike signals not only the end of innocence but also the beginning of an internal exile, where young women become strangers to themselves and the world around them. The idea of being "taken care of" is expanded upon in Part II of *Averno* in the poem "A Myth of Devotion". Here, Hades is portrayed as a devoted yet profoundly egocentric lover who takes Persephone into the Underworld simply because he "decided he loved this girl".[95] The speaker offers a glimpse into Hades' reasoning, revealing that he believes exposing Persephone to hell and darkness is an essential experience for her. He assumes that Persephone, whom he has seen "in the meadow, smelling and tasting the flowers",[96] is curious and would naturally want to explore the Underworld. Hades views himself as the provider of this forbidden knowledge; he seeks to fill what he perceives as a void in Persephone's life. Hades' interpretation of Persephone's actions in the meadow echoes psychological readings of the Persephone myth that view her descent into the Underworld as a symbolic rite of passage from childhood to adulthood. Under this perspective, Kore embodies the archetype of a girl coming of age, and Hades serves as a positive force in Persephone's growth (see the readings by Hall and Woolger and Barker in the section above). However, Glück's portrayal critiques this reading by exposing the disturbing self-centeredness of Hades' motives. He never considers Persephone's own desires, nor does he grasp the magnitude of what he forces her to sacrifice: the sensory pleasures of life in the upperworld. His love blinds him to the consequences of his actions: "It never crossed his mind / that there'd be no more smelling here, / certainly no more eating. / Guilt? Terror? The fear of love? / These things he couldn't imagine; / no lover ever imagines them."[97]

By juxtaposing Hades' perspective with the impact of his actions on Persephone, Glück highlights a truth about relationships rooted in unequal power dynamics: the guise of devotion often masks acts of control and possession. The fact that Hades believes he is acting out of love only intensifies the horror of Persephone's erasure. Glück presents two contrasting interpretations of the Persephone myth (strategy a: hybrid reading): Hades' self-justifying narrative and the implied reality of Persephone's suffering. This strategy enriches the classical depiction of the abduction, where ancient authors often dismiss Persephone's experience, reducing it to a single, desperate scream for help (see the *Hymn to Demeter* and the *Metamorphoses*). In this retelling, Glück brings to the fore elements of the myth that were previously only suggested – such as Persephone's fear, captured in her piercing scream. The author prioritises the exposition of Persephone's experience (strategy c: playful use of sources), thereby unveiling the psychic

[94]Ibid.
[95]Ibid., 58.
[96]Ibid.
[97]Ibid., 59.

cost of Hades' actions (strategy d: inversion of conventional meanings). At the same time, since the author also includes Hades' reasoning, the impossibility of excusing his actions is underscored.

The relationship dynamic depicted in "A Myth of Devotion" and "Prism" represents yet another inferno young women often endure on their path to adulthood: a form of psychological confinement, the emotional toll of love dictated by another's will. Glück's revision makes it clear that Hades' apparent love and devotion are not enough for a relationship to work. This subverts a key tenet of romantic love, the belief that love alone is sufficient, that it can conquer all. Moreover, in both poems, the notion of being "taken care of" becomes a sinister euphemism for the erasure of women's individuality and interiority. In "A Myth of Devotion", the speaker eloquently gives voice to this obliteration, describing how girls surrender themselves "without limit", leading to the dissolution of their identity: "the self ended and the world began".[98] This loss of self is not temporary; it leaves Persephone permanently altered.

In "October", "Averno", "Wanderer" (1), "Wanderer" (2), "Prism" and "A Myth of Devotion", Persephone returns to the upperworld blemished – her mind restless, her body scarred by violence. Glück's poems remind readers that the consequences of Persephone's abduction cannot be undone; nor can the consequences of her wandering, another form of violence. Persephone is doomed not by divine fate but by her mother's and lover's endless dispute. Ultimately, Glück's shape-shifting speaker – young and old, daughter and mother – reveals these hidden violences with the clarity of one who has survived them.

Conclusions

This paper has examined Louise Glück's *Averno* as a sophisticated reception of the Persephone myth, one informed by the author's solid understanding of the ancient sources yet decisively modern in its combination of classical scholarship with modernist and postmodernist concerns and techniques. Through a close reading of six poems, I have argued that Glück engages with the story of Persephone – and especially the goddess's abduction and descent into the Underworld – to expose the metaphorical infernos young women face as they transition to adulthood. This reading broadens our understanding of Glück's oeuvre and contributes to existing scholarship on *Averno*, situating the collection within contemporary discussions on the role and relevance of classical myth in our times.

Using the concepts and methods of Classical Reception Studies and Gender Studies, this paper has identified several strategies Glück employs in her reception of the Persephone story, which are essential to understanding both her version of the myth and her innovative approach to mythology: hybrid reading (a), meta-mythology (b), playful use of sources (c), inversion of conventional meanings (d), and feminist appropriation (e). These strategies lead to three main conclusions about Glück's retelling of the Persephone myth.

First, *Averno* is primarily concerned with articulating the experience of the Underworld and exposing the infernal trials it represents. Glück's reception strategies (a

[98]Ibid., 27.

through d) provide the means to give voice to these experiences. Her portrayal of Persephone's infernal journey reflects a vision shaped by the mythic space of the Underworld. In this vision, the speaker struggles to articulate the cause and nature of her trauma. She is reduced to an echo of her former self, a wanderer without a home and a stranger to the world. Moreover, the question of whether Persephone cooperated in her abduction is left unresolved; instead, Glück introduces a more nuanced reflection on the episode, where Persephone's consent is central. At times, an experienced (Demeterian) voice emerges to offer insight informed by her past as Kore. This suggests that speech from Averno – from a place of suffering – grants the vantage point of someone who has endured patriarchal violence and returned with knowledge.

Second, Glück's reception showcases a distinctly postmodern sensibility. Her poems combine classical and contemporary reading trends while adopting a self-aware, playful attitude towards poetic and mythic tradition. A third-person speaker, often Glück herself, frequently interrupts Persephone's story to comment on the craft of poetry and mythmaking. Notably, this speaker points to the multiple "prisms" (the title of the poem "Prism" is not incidental) through which myths can be viewed, and acknowledges the narrative choices involved in mythmaking. By showing how the Persephone myth refracts into multiple perspectives – simultaneously revealing and distorting the truth – Glück invites readers to be mindful of the malleability of myths and their potential for reinterpretation. This poetry collection thus not only revisits the Persephone myth but also interrogates the processes by which myths are shaped, adapted, and understood over time.

Third, *Averno* gives voice to the daughter's perspective and the specific pressures she faces. What is more, it asserts young women's right to resist the constraints imposed by both lovers and parents. Drawing on Lorna Hardwick's concept of appropriation, which refers to "using ancient images or texts to sanction subsequent ideas or practices", the appropriation offered by Glück has significant implications for our understanding of the mother-daughter and husband-wife relationships from the daughter's perspective. This perspective highlights the impact of Hades' self-serving motives on Persephone, while also – perhaps unexpectedly – casting Demeter not as a nurturing figure, but as a suffocating mother. This inversion reflects the author's ampler interrogation of women's oppression, which encompasses family conflict and complex, triangulated relationships.

While *Averno* engages with the gendered reinterpretations of the Persephone myth developed over the past century, it extends beyond them by reframing female oppression as not only a consequence of male figures like Hades but also of maternal control that can replicate patriarchal authority. Through this feminist appropriation, Glück fosters a sense of shared experience among women and creates a poetic space where girls' infernos find a voice. Overall, *Averno* offers a form of feminist solidarity, acknowledging the difficulties of growing up female.

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